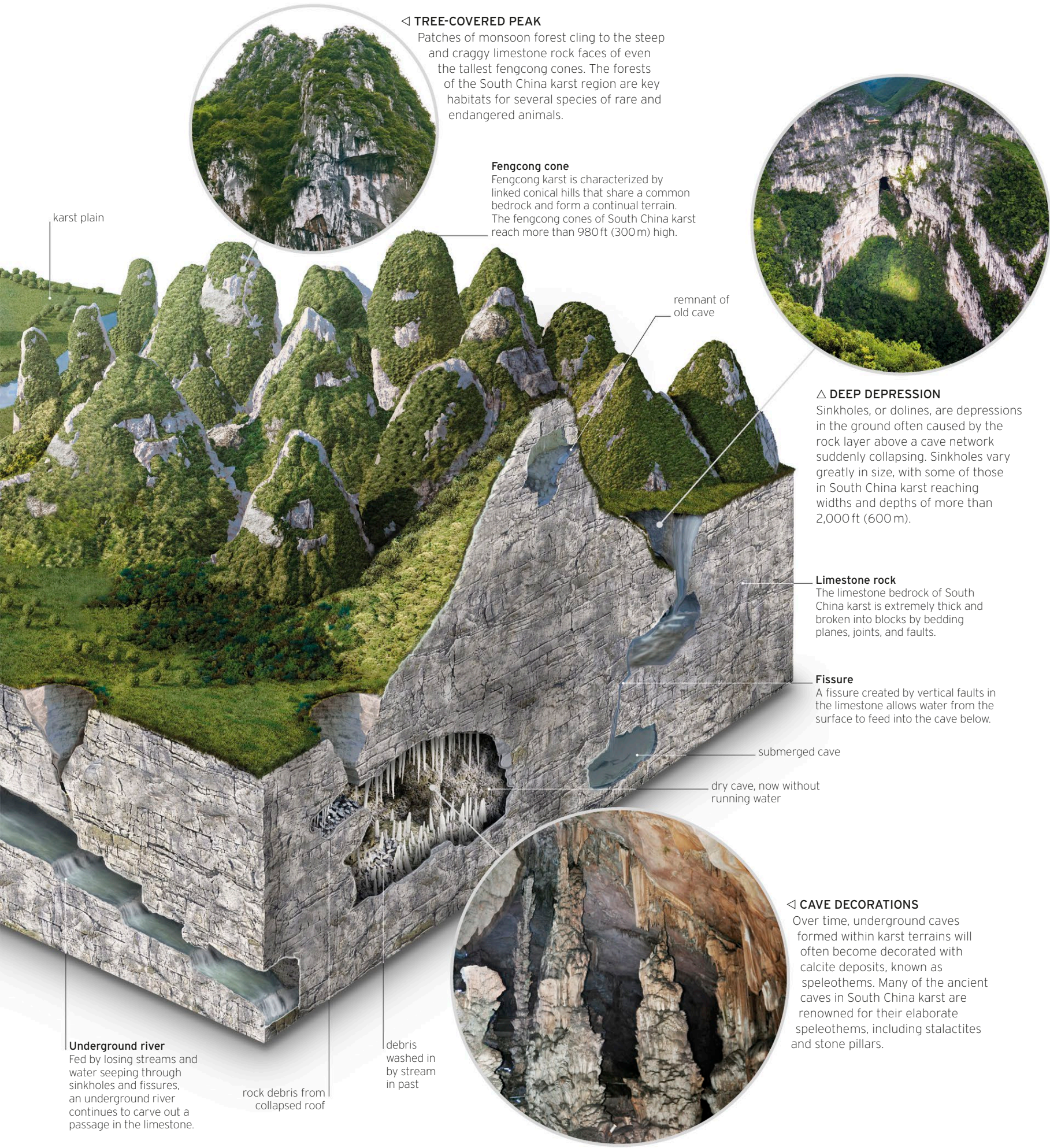




◁ TREE-COVERED PEAK

Patches of monsoon forest cling to the steep and craggy limestone rock faces of even the tallest fengcong cones. The forests of the South China karst region are key habitats for several species of rare and endangered animals.

Fengcong cone

Fengcong karst is characterized by linked conical hills that share a common bedrock and form a continual terrain. The fengcong cones of South China karst reach more than 980 ft (300 m) high.

△ DEEP DEPRESSION

Sinkholes, or dolines, are depressions in the ground often caused by the rock layer above a cave network suddenly collapsing. Sinkholes vary greatly in size, with some of those in South China karst reaching widths and depths of more than 2,000 ft (600 m).

Limestone rock

The limestone bedrock of South China karst is extremely thick and broken into blocks by bedding planes, joints, and faults.

Fissure

A fissure created by vertical faults in the limestone allows water from the surface to feed into the cave below.

◁ CAVE DECORATIONS

Over time, underground caves formed within karst terrains will often become decorated with calcite deposits, known as speleothems. Many of the ancient caves in South China karst are renowned for their elaborate speleothems, including stalactites and stone pillars.

Underground river

Fed by losing streams and water seeping through sinkholes and fissures, an underground river continues to carve out a passage in the limestone.